

Will concrete harm the Upper Barrakka trees?

A public claim, tested against the scientific literature

THE CLAIM

“Given its temporary nature, it will not cause damage to the tree.”

Ambjent Malta, to the Times of Malta, 1 October 2026

About concrete placed in the tree planters, to be removed once a waterproofing membrane is in.

The headline drops the “temporary” condition and simply says the concrete won’t damage the trees.

VERDICT

NOT SUBSTANTIATED

*Plausible,
but not shown.*

SUPPORTED

LARGELY
SUPPORTED

NOT
SUBSTANTIATED

MISLEADING

CONTRADICTED

MAIN RESULTS

Sound logic

Right reasoning

Ambjent itself says prolonged cover is a risk (water, bark, nutrients, decay). That matches the research.

Undefined

How long is “temporary”?

No duration is given, yet harm from sealing builds with time.

Not addressed

Soil removal and roots

Soil was taken out of the planter. Root exposure and clearing concrete off roots aren’t covered.

0 studies

On temporary cover

We found no research on short-term concrete contact with roots. For permanent sealing the science is mixed.

3–5+ years

Before damage shows

Decline often appears late, so “no tree has died” in five treated planters says little.

FAIR TO SAY

Protecting the Lascaris War Rooms from flooding is a legitimate aim. Ambjent responded within days and had concrete removed from the roots. This check covers only the tree-safety statement.

WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

☐ How long the concrete stayed on each planter.

☐ How roots were protected, and that none were cut.

☐ An arborist’s report, plus crown monitoring for several years.

☐ How the sealed planters drain and how the trees will be watered.